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Junior Mance
Part II

Pianist Junior Mance was born in Chicago on October 10, 1928. He studied at Roosevelt College and gained early experience with Gene Ammons and Lester Young. During his military service, Junior played with the Adderley brothers, later joining their quintet in 1956. He has recorded and toured with Dizzy Gillespie, Dinah Washington and Joe Williams and currently leads his own trio. The strong blues influence in his playing makes him immediately recognizable and he has composed a number of classic jazz tunes, including "Harlem Lullaby."

Part II was conducted in New York City by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive, on January 18, 1999.

MR: [false start]

MR: We are filming in Manhattan, it's Martin Luther King Day and I'm very pleased to have Junior Mance with me as my guest for a second interview for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. Welcome.

JM: Thank you. It's a pleasure to be here again.

MR: I've been looking forward to following up on some of the things we talked about the first time, and actually wanted to get an update on where you've been. I know you are well traveled.

JM: That I am.

MR: So since — gee it's been two years I think at least. What are some highlights of the places you've been since then?

JM: Well I go to Japan a lot. I still do the 100 Gold Fingers Tour. In fact we're doing it this year, it starts in May, May 23rd, until June 8th, and we're doing that again. And I've been pretty much to most of the same places, most out of the country though. To Japan, Europe or Canada. I go to Toronto a lot. I do the jazz festival there and there's a club there I play annually.

MR: Do you handle all your own business affairs?

JM: I do, believe it or not. I've had a lot of managers in my life, some good, some bad. But I don't know, I just decided to try it myself and you know I kind of like it. It's very time consuming you know. My days are as busy as my nights. Like usually even when I'm not working I'm on the phone all day. But I kind of like it. It's kind of nice to know more about the business. I've been teaching more also, at the New School, University it's called now, instead of the New School of Social Research. Yeah, the jazz department has grown tremendously. And I'm teaching two classes there, a week, blues ensemble

classes. And I'm still doing private teaching. And that I like. You know I never thought I would like it so much. A couple of my colleagues asked me to try it, and I've been at it ten years now, as an adjunct.

MR: Do you take on students who already play piano?

JM: I do.

MR: And they want to learn —

JM: I do. I don't take on beginners, no. Because that I'm not very experienced, in teaching anybody in the very beginning. When I try to think about myself I think, I was unusual. I don't want to teach anyone like me. But no, most of the students that I get are really good players. I'm able to select them. And the blues classes are great too. We still get people from everywhere, I mean all over the world. I think, when I started, last time I talked to you I think our enrollment was, oh under 50 people. Now it's over 200.

MR: I understand they just had some dealings with the union or something?

JM: Yeah. It worked out. I had misgivings, but they were able to pull it off. Because being adjunct it was hard to get the things they were asking for, but we got them. Yeah, we got a raise in salary. But the main thing they were campaigning for was benefits, pension, health insurance and all that. We got it all.

MR: Wow. Maybe I should send your team up to where I work.

JM: You know what they were the first ones in the City and I understand that a lot of the other programs like ours are investigating it.

MR: Yeah, they're going to sit up and take notice now.

JM: In fact there's a couple in the New School, they're not music programs, but they have adjunct professors and adjunct teachers, and they're going after it. They've hired our lawyers, and asking advice, like from our team, from the union people.

MR: Are you able to teach the blues and improvising without getting too technical with it? I'm not sure I asked that right.

JM: You are saying it right. Because as I mentioned before, the last time, when they asked me to teach the blues, I said well how do you teach anybody to play the blues? And the answer was, oh you'll find a way. Believe it or not I'm still looking for the right way, yeah. But actually I try to leave all the technical aspects out of it because then it becomes like a structured blues thing, which most of them already know. They know there is 12-bar blues, some of them don't know that there are 8-bar blues and even 16-bar blues and 24-bar blues or 20-bar blues. But that takes no time to show them. So I stick with more the feeling, the spiritual or emotional side of it. And it works. And I guess I have sometimes the same students keep coming back. I've had students who come back all four years. And these are like the better students, the A students, and they keep coming back. And I find myself, I don't know whether this sort of pushes me a little bit to come

up with different ideas. But I do each semester. And I think this is why it's still fun to me. And I've asked different students, why do you keep coming back? Oh man, we love this class, we learn something every time. And it's for all instruments, not just piano. You know it's an ensemble. That's why they changed the name of it to ensemble because we usually have enough people like for a band. I had to sort of put a clamp, a cap on it, because sometimes I was stuck with like six piano players. The class is two hours long and everybody's not going to get a chance to play. So now I limited it to two piano players, two drummers and two bass players so they can trade off. Horns I sort of am a little looser on that, because that's always different. Like last semester I had four saxophone players and four trumpets which was great. But the thing we're short of, strangely enough in the school, is trombone players. There are only two trombone players in the whole school.

MR: I can relate to that. Same thing up where we are.

JM: Really?

MR: I don't know I think it's fallen out of — maybe not out of favor — but it's just not an instrument that is attracting a lot of —

JM: Well it's not an easy instrument, playing the trombone is like learning how to play the violin, which is supposed to be the hardest instrument to learn, because they have the positions. The slide is like positions on the violin.

MR: Do you ever get any string players in the class?

JM: I had a jazz cello player last semester, from Italy, who was fantastic. Like his idol was, remember when Oscar Pettiford made those records playing jazz cello? And he played like that, but he loves the blues. And he's coming back. And he's also a wonderful bass player too so he's going to come back doubling. He's the only string player, unless you want to call a guitar player. That's another one I had to weed out because I was getting six and seven guitar players every semester, so I told them no more than two guitar players for each class.

MR: Do you memorize some heads with them?

JM: Yes.

MR: Do you make them memorize melodies?

JM: Um humm. In fact, we try to work more on heads rather than music. Some things we might use say a lead sheet. But if you notice blues bands, they're very improvisational on the gig. You know you hear them come up with these backgrounds and things, you know like making up just on the spot. And this is what I'm trying to teach them to do and they love that. The first couple of weeks they're kind of in the dark, then somebody will — as they used to say in the old days — set a riff, and they pick it up like that. And they're all good musicians because well still as before, you have to audition to get into the school.

And you have to be a sophomore to get into my class. So they are pretty well trained on things like that by the time they get there. It works good. Because I tell them stories like Sweets Edison told me once that the Basie Band of the late '30s and early '40s did not have a book, they had no written music. And some of those early records you hear are head arrangements. I say are you serious? He says yeah. Somebody in a section will just like pay a riff and I guess their ears are so trained from playing jazz, jazz being improvisational I guess you must have good ears. And they would pick it up just like that, and you would think that all of this stuff was written out. But now it's all written out you know, but back then, he says no.

MR: Yeah, in fact I hear stories about guys who used to accidentally lose parts from things that got too difficult.

JM: Oh yeah. You remember the famous baritone player Serge Chaloff, he played with Woody Herman. Well Serge was a wonderful baritone player but he memorized the whole book. But he had a habit of coming to work late or coming back after the intermission too late, and Woody was getting sick of it, and told him next time you're going to get fired, next time you're late. And Serge showed up late and Woody fired him right there, or gave him his two weeks' notice. So the bus was traveling you know. And so they were crossing a bridge over a river, so Serge took his book, the baritone book and he flung it out the window into the river, and he looked at Woody and says, "You can't fire me." He says, "I got it all up here." And he did. He knew every part. And there are some players that are like that. I remember Gene Ammons was like that. I mean not as far as being late, but I mean as far as they have a photographic memory. Gene Ammons, we played in a local big band called Jimmy Dale's big band in Chicago. And Gene would just look at the music once and he's got every note up there. And he concentrated then on phrasing. So he became as important to the reed section as the lead alto player. In fact even the lead alto player, they'd want to follow his leading because he would have the right inflections or the right spirit. And so like I say Serge was like that too. He told him, "You can't fire me." And he couldn't until somebody copied the book again or wrote the parts out, and that took a while, because they had a book like it was that thick.

MR: That was nasty. I think I heard a follow up or something about Woody Herman getting back to him, something in the Bill Crow book. Pretty nasty actually.

JM: He probably did.

MR: Something about using his leg as a urinal or something.

JM: Yes. Yeah that's true. It was a bar or something. I heard that that was a true story.

MR: Well you're mentioning Gene Ammons reminds me — I wanted to ask you about — for the first part of your career you were playing with different combos and stuff. And eventually you got to a point where you started becoming your own leader, of your trio.

JM: Yeah. That was years later though after Gene Ammons. I think it was about 1961 that I gave serious thought to becoming a leader. Because I made my first record as a leader in ’58 or ’59, it was a Verve record called “Just Plain Junior.” I was playing with Dizzy at the time. And Norman Granz, who then was the owner of Verve records, was also the producer. So he came out of the booth during the break and said, “How would you like to do your own album?” And I was speechless. I didn’t know what to say. Finally I said yes. And so I did the first album which had Ray Brown on bass. He says, “Do you mind using Ray Brown?” Are you out of your mind? Are you kidding? Of course, I’d love to use him. And not taking anything away — we had a great bass player in Dizzy’s band at the time, we had Sam Jones, who I had already made up my mind well Sam’s going on play on this. In fact Dizzy’s rhythm section, Sam and the drummer at the time named Lex Humphries. But Ray sort of was Norman’s or Verve Records’ house bass player, he was on all their records. So I said yes I’d love to use him. And that was the first record. And all the reviews, the magazines and the critics and everything they were giving it four stars and five stars, and I said yeah. And I did with Dizzy’s blessings. Because you know at that time I guess I was in my third year with Dizzy. In fact I spent just about three years with him. And that’s when I tried it. It was a struggle but I don’t regret it. I still like playing trio best. I’ve tried other configurations of bands. In fact the record we had come out last year during the jazz cruise, the Floating Jazz Festival Trio featuring Joe Temperley, well Joe and I work together a lot, you know Joe is a wonderful baritone player. In fact to me he’s the best. And he’s playing other instruments too. He’d do things where he’s playing the bass clarinet. And so we worked together quite a bit in between times, because he’s with the Lincoln Center Jazz Orchestra, and they love him there, and Wynton Marsalis is crazy about him. He’s the oldest guy in the band but probably the one with the most experience. And he had that sound, that blending sound.

MR: Yeah. I have that CD you mentioned.

JM: Oh you do?

MR: I love that version you do of “In a Sentimental Mood” with him way up high on the baritone.

JM: Right. Doesn’t he get a great sound?

MR: It’s really very evocative.

JM: Yeah. It’s not harsh or coarse like a lot of baritones can sound that get up there.

MR: It almost sounds like a Joe Williams singing falsetto or something.

JM: Right, yeah. Yeah and we also do a thing on there where he does bass clarinet I think, we do the medley of “Single Petal of a Rose” and “Sunset and Mockingbird.” On “Single Petal of a Rose” he plays that on the bass clarinet.

MR: What was Dizzy like as a employer?

JM: Wonderful. Yeah. One thing I liked about Dizzy, when you joined his band he didn't try to change the way you play. You know like a lot of us, me included, when we play with somebody like that we sort of have a tendency to play like the person that was before us. You know like I found myself trying to do things the other piano player did. And finally he tells you he says, "Look I hired you because of the way you play, that's what I want to hear. I don't want to hear you playing like somebody else plays, bring your own thing." Because I was in a small group. I had did a couple of weeks with the big band before he had a special thing where he had to get a big band together, like I remember a week in Birdland with the big band, and on one of the festivals somewhere where he brought the whole band, but other than that it was always with the quintet. And so after that for me it was a learning process. Playing with Dizzy those three years, I probably learned more of what I wanted to learn than the three years that I'd studied at music school or with teachers etcetera. And just by listening. And he was always eager to show you things. By coincidence we lived in the same neighborhood at the same time out in Queens. And I was only about maybe a seven or eight minute walk to his house and he'd invite me over and he had a studio in his basement. And we'd go down there and he'd show me like alternate chord changes to things and just a lot of things.

MR: He played the piano too, didn't he?

JM: Yes he did. He had such a knowledge of the piano. You know he had a knowledge of chords that piano players didn't have. I mean great, wonderful chords too. And so as I said it was a complete learning process for me. It was just so great. And the last gig he played in New York I was on it. He did a whole month at the Blue Note celebrating his 75th birthday, which he did all year, you know every place he went. But he was the only one, it was unprecedented that anyone would work a month in the Blue Note. But each week was different. The first week I think was the big band, the second week was the saxophone players, mostly the ones that had worked with him, the third one I think was the Latin thing, I'm not sure, but I think that was one of the weeks. And the week that I worked with him, the last week was all the trumpet players. Let's see, Wynton Marsalis, who else —

MR: Jon Faddis perhaps.

JM: Jon Faddis, Claudio Roditi. Roy Hargrove. Every night a different trumpet player. And that album came out and it was called "To Dizzy With Love." And I had such a ball playing with him. It was like the first time I'd played with him for any length of time since I met the dude, and I was just really turned on because I idolized him so much, I'd learned so much from him. And comping, and the other horn players, I'd do something and he'd turn around and look at me and smile and wink. And so when he died I was in tears because the last thing he told me, at the end of the gig that week, you know I

stopped in his dressing room and said, "Dizzy, thanks for inviting me to do this week, it was really a treat for me." And he looked at me and grabbed me and hugged me and said, "You're finally doing it." You don't know how much that meant to me. Because he had showed me so much. And he said, "You're doing it, just keep on." That was the last thing he said to me. He said, "See you next time." There wasn't a next time. In fact that's when he got ill, when he left New York then and he went out to the coast and I think he passed out or something, and died of pancreatic cancer.

MR: Well it's great that they had that month for him and you were involved.

JM: It is. I don't know if they released every week, I know I think the saxophone players they released, and the trumpet players. They might come out with them, you know they might hold them back.

MR: Who was the saxophone player — was James Moody on the band when you were there?

JM: No, I wasn't in the band with James Moody. I've played a lot of gigs with Moody, I sure wish he had been there. It was Leo Wright, an alto player that's passed away also, a young alto player originally from Texas but he lived in Germany a great part of his life. He was stationed in the Army there. And then when he finished his Army duty he just stayed there and married and had a family. But he came back after that, and that's when he joined Dizzy. Before that there was no saxophone player, it was Les Spann playing guitar and flute, which is a strange double. But he was wonderful though, Les played good both rhythmically and solo-wise. And he and Dizzy did a lot of flute and muted trumpet duets which was nice. One album we did called "Have Trumpet Will Excite" features that a lot, the two of them, and also another one called "The Ebullient Mr. Gillespie." It was actually one session but we had so much stuff that they did it in two albums.

MR: Were you able, as a member of that group, were you paid per gig or were you on a salary type.

JM: Salary type, yeah. Because we worked all the time. We were on the road like 40 weeks a year.

MR: I remember you saying when you first heard bop that you were with a group of people who, obviously somebody had introduced it to you who said this is great stuff, and the other people or person you were with said no, no, no, don't play that.

JM: Yeah the man I was playing with: "You don't want to play that garbage." And the first time, I was very young then, I was maybe 17 or 18, somewhere in there, and I heard a young alto player who was playing like Charlie Parker, and I had never heard Charlie Parker before I heard this alto player. He was about my age. And wow, it just touched me, and he had his buddy, who was playing trumpet like Dizzy. In fact in Chicago they used to call this guy "Little Diz." And it turned me on. So I started playing like Bud

Powell, because I started listening to records, and I was working with this group which was primarily a rhythm and blues group, that's what you would call it today. And strange enough, the saxophone player and the drummer in the group were also turned on by bebop. So the drummer just got tired of brow beating. You know, "Man why don't you play straight, what are you dropping all those bombs for?" And he quit. And after a while the saxophone player quit. And I quit too because he replaced them with people who weren't on that level yet, and it became more or less just like a honky tonk band. Which now I look back, there's nothing wrong with that, it was a good honky tonk band.

MR: Did you play mostly for dancing at the time?

JM: Dancing and floor shows. Like not strippers but shake dancers, tap dancers, blues singers, just a show, in clubs mostly, in regular night clubs. So they wanted to keep it that way.

MR: Did you ever have occasion in those situations where someone would bring in a four page piece of music for the piano player, and you're going "oh God, where's the chord symbols?"

JM: Oh, I feel the same way. I was never a fast sight reader. But you know as a kid I learned how to read music but it's something that, you have to keep doing it. Once you stop, you're going to not do it as well. And I stopped for years, because I went to the small band type way of playing. My reading was probably best right after high school and my first year of Roosevelt College. I was with this local big band, the one I was talking about that Gene Ammons played in. It was like the Thad Jones-Mel Lewis band of today. All the heavyweights were in the band. Lee Konitz was in the band also. And we rehearsed more than we worked. We rehearsed every week on a certain day, I think it was a Wednesday or Thursday we'd get together, and the leader was a guy that passed away last year, named Harold Fox. He was a trumpet player and his family owned a tailoring business that outfitted every band just about in the country. And so Harold more or less took over I think after his father passed or retired, Harold took over the store, and Harold knew all the band leaders then. And he was trading them suits or uniforms to outfit the band, for arrangements out of their books. People like Woody Herman, Stan Kenton, some of Lionel Hampton's book, even the Billy Eckstine Big Band. And Dizzy's big band. We had every big band. We had a book that thick of these great arrangements. So I was in that band, and you know they had these long sheets like that, but the music was so good that it encouraged me to read music. But after that I never played in a big band again until Dizzy's band. I was on some record dates where they had these long sheets, but record dates, fortunately for the piano player and the guitar player, they wrote mostly just chord changes, which is much easier to read than when the music is spelled out. And so it sort of got away. When people ask me now, "Are you a good reader?" I say, "Well let's put it this way: I spell, I don't read, I can spell it." That's why I like teaching the

blues, maybe that's something in the back of my mind as to why I don't have that much music. I have some tunes you know. Occasionally I let them work on a bebop tune and let an ensemble do it, but other than that I just sort of got away from it. I was never that interested in getting back to it. I was never interested; and doing studio work, which is probably the most lucrative part of the business you know. Like look at the studio musicians now, even those into retirement, man they have pensions in five and six figures. Mine is barely in three figures you know. But studio work is like a nine to five job to me. It's done mostly in the daytime where you have to be in the studio early, and you're always playing somebody else's music. And that doesn't — I won't say it rubs the wrong way, but I think I would get very bored playing. And I just never pursued playing studio music. Even though I was asked, "Why don't you think about it?" But I think another thing too, because I was playing with so many of my heroes when I was young, so many of my idols, like Lester Young, and Gene Ammons of course and Leo Parker, the late Leo Parker, the baritone player. And then when I got out of the Army I had this gig at the Beehive Lounge in Chicago, where I was with the house band with Israel Crosby on bass, another local drummer named Buddy Smith playing drums, and they brought in singles, like Charlie Parker worked there for a month, shoot one time I worked with Charlie Parker. He was one of the people that influenced me to come to New York. On the gig he says, "You should come to New York." And when I finally showed up in New York I ran into him one day downtown, and he says, "So you finally made it" he was telling me and I said, "Yep, I'm here to stay, too." And people like that, Coleman Hawkins played the Beehive, Eddie "Lockjaw" Davis, Sonny Stitt, just about everybody you can name. And they all came without groups. And this club would book them for at least a month.

MR: Did they ever bring their own library, or they just expected you to know —

JM: No, they just brought themselves.

MR: And they'd say okay here's what we're doing.

JM: Yeah.

MR: Were there occasions where you'd have to say I don't know that but tomorrow I will?

JM: Yeah, yeah. Sometimes I'd learn it on the gig. Maybe I'd heard the tune but had never played it. They stuck pretty much to standards, plus most of them, you know I was great for listening to records in those days. Like in the Army, I was in the Army with Cannonball and we had more records than we had clothes in our barracks. We had two record players and we shared a room, because I was the Company Clerk, and Cannonball was the head of the Band Training Unit. And we had two record players to begin with, and we must have had at least a hundred albums apiece. We were always buying records too. And so all these guys that came here, I knew most of their originals.

MR: Ooh, nice.

JM: And two people that came in there, I learned probably more standards than I'd learned before. Coleman Hawkins was one and Charlie Parker was the other. They played a lot of standards. Of course everybody knew all of Charlie Parker's originals anyway. But they would call a standard and you pretty much knew it. And I'd ask them well what key do you want it in? And they both had the same answer. They said "make it easy on yourself." It didn't matter. And it didn't. They were at home in any key. So I'd ask them, I'd say, "Well what's the original?" Because I knew that everybody that was going to play the tune again and nobody was going to — most people knew the tune in the original key, that was the standard, and they would tell me. They'd say but if you want to play it in another key, go ahead. And that was a learning experience. I learned more standards from those two. Coleman Hawkins, he had a wealth of standards, standards I never heard of.

MR: Non-standard standards.

JM: Yeah, right.

MR: I wanted to play a little snippet of something from your early career.

JM: Oh yeah?

MR: Well in those days, and see if it rings a bell with you.

[audio interlude]

JM: Is that — that's not from that jam session album with Dinah Washington?

MR: No, this is with Cannonball and Nat. The tune is called "Spectacular."

JM: [scats] "Spectacular" right, yeah. Jimmy Cobb on drums and Sam Jones. You know when that was? 1956. Forty something years, forty two years ago.

MR: Man, I listened to that and I'm wondering if you ever were in a situation on a record like that and they're counting off the tune like that, and you're going, oh please, not that fast. That sounded awful fast to me.

JM: Believe it or not, I'm in a situation now — I still like to play fast but not as often. But this was the thing in Chicago, I don't know why, all the tenor players liked to play fast, which is what I worked with mostly. Gene Ammons loved to play fast and way up there. But he never would record that fast. Johnny Griffin still plays a mile a minute. He's from Chicago also, and we worked together a few times, and I think every other tune was like that. And even we played a lot of fast tunes when he and Lockjaw Davis had the quintet. There was a lot of fast tunes there. And when I came to New York, and I'd go to a session and say, "What do you want to play?" And they'd look at me and say, "When are you going to stop that?" So actually I did, because I found out something, that playing fast is easier than playing like this, playing at this tempo. Because at this tempo you've

got to think of something meaningful to play. But when you play fast like that, you know you can put your exercises together so to speak, you know the changes.

MR: Right. Running the changes.

JM: Exactly, yeah. And it's easier playing like that. And after a while I enjoyed playing, maybe a little faster than that. And I enjoy that because it says more. You know you have to think and construct a nice melodic solo. And I love playing ballads now more than I used to. In fact I'm now playing the melody, maybe phrasing it differently, which is almost the same concept as a conductor with classical music. He's not going to change the notes but he may add his own conception of phrasing for a particular work. And this is what I sort of equate it to. And it's like Ben Riley the drummer. He used to tell me, "If you stop playing fast, call me, I'd like to work with you." And now he tells me, "You haven't called me yet. I figured you'd finally stop going boogity boogity," he used to say. But Cannonball used to like to play fast. Because this was right after we both got out of the Army. And we used to do that a lot. We changed drummers a lot working with Cannonball, but Jimmy Cobb could handle it. And the drummer we had before Jimmy Cobb, Specs Wright could also handle it very well. But I mean myself, drummers you know when they were finished, I don't know if you remember the Redd Foxx show, you know he says "atharitis" he would call it, and hold his hand like that. The drummer when he finished, said, "Man look what you do to me."

MR: I always feel sorry for the bass players too. It just seems like such — after a while the locked —

JM: But they can handle it easier, because with the amplifiers, they wouldn't have to play as hard. They could play lighter and just turn the amplifier up and it would come out just as loud. And then the modern day bass players, well the old bass players used to play with just those two fingers like that. But now they play with all the fingers, so they can handle those tempos now a little easier.

MR: Okay you probably know that I was going to play this next little piece, somewhere in here. This has some significance for me.

[audio interlude]

MR: Is there a story behind this piece? The way you sat down —

JM: No. Not really. I didn't know what to call it, and then "Harlem Lullaby" stuck. But believe it or not I just recorded it again and I did it on this live session. And the producer liked it so well that I just did a record for them a few months ago. It should be out either this month or next month. And he asked me would I do it again for the session, I mean in the studio, and I did it. And I would have to send you that one because you know after you've done a tune a lot, then sometimes it either gets better or worse. Because sometimes you can get tired of doing it. I think I did the best one I ever did on this last

session. For one thing, recording for Enja, this particular producer I had, Horst Weber out of Munich, he insists on any, even in the studio, it's almost like doing a live date because he will only use first takes. And just by coincidence he has the same idea about recording, which is, when you've got to do two or three takes, and I've always had this idea, if I have to repeat a thing, it goes downhill. Usually the first take, you've got the feeling that you want. You may miss a few notes. Horst doesn't care. He says that's jazz, everybody misses notes in jazz. It's just that some of the older players, some of us know how to cover up. You know, we make a mistake, we make it sound right. And I don't know I just felt pretty good. We did the session at night, myself and Earl May and Jackie Williams. And Earl and Jackie played a tune with me before. That's usually the trio I use most of the time now except on the Floating Jazz Festival trios, Keter Betts is the bass player because he was sort of like the house bass player after Major Holley died. In fact we were put together as a trio on the cruise sort of by accident. And it was on the Royal Caribbean line too, it was a tribute to Benny Carter cruise, and the three of us played and we accompanied Benny and did nights by ourselves. And I don't know it sort of just clicked. And at the end of the cruise Hank O'Neal, the producer of the group, he says, "Listen, can I record you guys in the studio?" I says, "Sure." Hell we thought it would be down the line, but the next day he says, "We're going to record at Rudy Van Gelder's." "Oh?" He says, "Can you be ready this afternoon?" And we were. That's when we did this album called "Blue Mance."

MR: Yes I have that.

JM: Yeah, that was the day after the cruise. And so we recorded every time since then. But anyway, that's why Keter, Keter lives in Washington, D.C. and he's busy with a lot of things, and he's on the Board I think of BET, the Black Entertainment Network in the jazz department. Like I see him playing on there so much you know with most of the groups, plus as I say he's on the Board of Directors also. So he's very busy. He's involved in the Head Start program.

MR: Right. Working with real little ones.

JM: Right. Oh he loves doing that. So Earl May has been sort of our regular bass player. Earl is like a Rock of Gibraltar. He and Jackie like play so good together. And Jackie is like one of the best rhythm drummers I've played with. The two of them together. I heard a guy say once, "The time is so good you can set your watch by it."

MR: Well this tune also contains one of the best — I just have to play this lick.

JM: Yeah but anyway, that night we just all felt good playing it, and it was a one take thing. [audio interlude]

MR: Beautiful.

JM: Yeah, I'll have to send you the new one. It's played the same but a different solo. And maybe something Jackie and Earl contributed to it. But Horst Weber, the producer, he loves that tune.

MR: Well he's got good taste then I think.

JM: So we did it for him.

MR: Do you have, when you finish a tune like that, do you write it out — in what shape or form?

JM: I write it out usually after I record it, for publishing purposes. But actually that tune, and "Jubilation," they're not the only tunes I wrote, but probably the more meaningful. "Jubilation" was the first tune I ever wrote, that was when I was with Cannonball, I wrote that in '55. And I still get tremendous royalties from it, from Japan especially. They love that tune over there. In fact I recorded it with other groups in Japan three or four times. You know, groups that asked me to be on their record. And here they come with "Jubilation." Some of them even come with it written out.

MR: Wow, man, that's high praise.

JM: It is. I consider it so.

MR: Gee the Japanese jazz audience is really quite well informed.

JM: Oh man, aren't they. They know so much about you, you think they slept under your bed. They're writing out everything about you. They know everything. I'll tell you, they buy more American jazz records than Americans do. A record is never taken out of print. Like the first record I ever made, "Junior," on Verve, that's still available on CD. The same cover, same album notes. And now it's an import here. They imported it from Verve and then they're exporting it back. Because I was in Tower one day and I saw it, I said oh it's available here now. And I looked at the price on it — $23.00. Because it was an import. I said are they nuts? $23.00 yeah. But they had it on sale. In fact a lot of jazz records that are hard to find here, in Tokyo especially I like to frequent the record stores there, there's one called Wave, W-A-V-E that's the name of the store. They've got about two floors of just any jazz record you can name. You can ask the guy, "oh yeah, we have that." And I remember one year I spent over $400 on records. Because CDs are higher there. They're in the vicinity of about $20.00 apiece. So that's only about 20 records I bought. But they're all records that were out of print long ago in the States. But now they're coming back, because I bought a lot of records through NARAS, you know the National Academy of Recording Arts and Sciences — the Grammy people. And I get them for seven bucks apiece because I'm a member, a voting member. That's why they send us this monthly catalogue with all the new releases. And believe it or not, over half of the jazz releases they have are reissues. And when you get them they're from Japan —

they've got this Japanese writing, and the covers inside. And so they are available here now, so I don't have to buy quite as many at $20.00.

MR: Would you ever go out and buy your own record?

JM: I have.

MR: You have.

JM: Only because it was so old and maybe — you know I like to keep a copy at home. And if it was scratched or something.

MR: I think you told me you didn't have this.

JM: No I didn't. Ohh.

MR: Yeah, but you can't have this.

JM: No, now I do. There's a guy — yeah, I was fat then. Yeah well you can't tell much, but I was weighing about 210.

MR: Really.

JM: Yeah. I'm down to about 175 now.

MR: That's a nice shot right there, just Junior and his record. Well you looked in good shape to me.

JM: Yeah, that's the record you wanted. That's the original "Harlem Lullaby." That's the first one.

MR: Yes. I had to look around for this. Because I originally owned it.

JM: That's the version that was playing here. Yeah. And it sounded great.

MR: Yeah it's great. This is also the record you did the harpsichord on.

JM: Oh yeah.

MR: Remember?

JM: That was a trip.

MR: [scats] — no, I'm singing "Take Five." There was a —

JM: "Uptown."

MR: "Uptown."

JM: The hardest thing about that was, you know the harpsichord, it wasn't an electric harpsichord, it was an acoustic harpsichord. They're so delicate, and so light, that, like if you notice in an orchestra even, when a harpsichord plays, the rest of the orchestra isn't playing behind them. Like they're playing passages, solo passages. Because the instrument is so light and so soft. And you can't hammer it to play it.

MR: It doesn't make any difference, right.

JM: Yeah you've got to play it lightly, yeah. So the way we had to do that, I had to record it with the rhythm section, you know on three different tracks, and then they take the rhythm section tracks and put them through the earphones and then I'd play it on the harpsichord and the harpsichord's been boosted to the level in the earphones. But they

tell me that for release they had to boost it about five times to make it sound level. And that's what it sounds like.

MR: Where did the idea come from to use the harpsichord?

JM: Actually there was a harpsichord in the studio. Somebody must have recorded some harpsichord music maybe before that and I was just fooling around with it, and the producer said, "Hey, let's do a tune with you playing harpsichord." I said, "Yeah, why not?" And we did. It's been done before, I'm not the first one to do that. Johnny Guarnieri did it when he was with — I think it was Johnny Guarnieri, with the Gramercy Five Artie Shaw band. Yeah, they did a bunch of things with a harpsichord and a five piece combo. And probably they did it the same way because I don't think they had the electric harpsichord then. Now they've got electric harpsichords, you know that they use for jazz or other pop music. And they can boost it up, and you can record right there on the same level.

MR: Did you ever have an occasion to use the Rhodes?

JM: Not on a gig. I'm not fond of electric pianos or electronic instruments. To listen to them yes. To play them no. Because the touch is too different. Same with the organ. The organ is entirely different touch than playing the piano. But I like to listen to a lot of things. You know there's a lot of things Herbie Hancock has done a Fender Rhodes, or Bob James is another one that used it, great on the electric piano. But personally for myself — I had one once and the only reason I bought it was because I could put the earphones on at night, you know I live in a high rise building and the walls are thin in today's apartment buildings. And I wanted to practice on it. But I use it mainly for composing not for playing. And I got tired of it, I got bored with it, and I gave it to a student. The students didn't have anything to practice on and the student was more into writing, into composition. And I gave it to him so that he could work and do his homework at home, because he lived in a place where he couldn't play at night also. I just bought one, I bought a Yamaha but I didn't buy it to practice, the reason I bought it was I bought a computer which I know nothing about yet. My wife does so she's going to teach me. Being a teacher she's really into the computers. And I bought this Yamaha keyboard, a 61 note keyboard — oh sorry about that.

MR: I thought I was hearing things.

JM: It's noon and this alarm goes off.

MR: Some time to get up — at noon.

JM: Oh I'll tell you a funny story about this in a minute. So the reason I bought it was for composing with the computer. They have music software. One's called Finale and one's called Encore. And I want to get into that.

MR: I've done some Finale.

JM: Really?

MR: Yeah.

JM: Ben Brown, the bass player, gave me Finale and Encore because I think he upgraded and he gave me probably the older ones. But I still haven't learned how to use them.

MR: There's enough there to learn, believe me.

JM: Yeah. So I want to really get into that. I might use it more like for the classroom work. Anytime I want to do parts I can do them, and play them and they'll come out. So that's the only reason I bought it, just to use as a midi. I was going to tell you about this watch. Last year I was doing jury duty. You know and with jury duty you have to get there early on occasion. And I'm not an early morning person at all. So I'm leaning on my hands and I'm falling asleep, so after a while this thing goes off, and it's quiet in the room, it's like between the district attorney questioning the person. And everybody stops. And so I happened to open my eyes, because the quiet will wake you more than noise will. And the judge is looking around and he looked at the clock, and the clock said exactly what my watch said, twelve o'clock. And so the lady sitting next to me, she touched me and she said, "I think that's you." And then I said, "Oh my goodness" and I shut it off, and I said, "Sorry, your honor." And even he got a kick out of it. He says, "It's lunch time anyway, recess." So I think the rest of the jury, were also glad that my thing went off. I know I was because I was finding it hard to stay awake. And it was a boring case and they do give you recesses if they find you are like really getting bored or sleepy and tired. They want you fresh all the time. So we took a lunch break. But it was embarrassing. You know I woke up and the whole courtroom, they're looking right at me like I'm on trial or something.

MR: "I'm innocent."

JM: The judge smiles and cracked a laugh. I said, "Sorry about that." So the next day I wore a different watch, I should have worn it today.

MR: Just a couple of things. I have noticed an awful lot of press, jazz is getting a lot of press lately. It seems like almost every week in the *New York Times* there's some article about something. Has it translated to a better working situation do you think for musicians?

JM: Well as far as New York there are more clubs. For the working situation, I think that's something the union is going to address next, the clubs. For a lot of reasons the clubs aren't paying the benefits or they're behind on them, you know the pension fund and all that. Like you know the Broadway shows, the Broadway theaters do, and the studios naturally do, the recording companies. The clubs are the only ones. But that's another subject altogether. As far as the music itself and playing, I think it's better. I do. The working conditions are much better. The club I work in mostly, I travel so much that when I get home usually I want to just enjoy home. And now that I'm married anyway,

especially. But the club Zinno's is the club I work more than any other club. The owner is probably one of my best friends anyway. And it's just around the corner from my house. I hang out in there a lot. They used to just do duos, but they moved the music room to the back, it's bigger now, and they have groups. So I can work there with the quartet, you know the trio plus Joe, Joe Temperley. And it's just a joy working there because there's no, you know, watching the clock or anything. We play what we want to play. And most of the — there's a lot happening in jazz. The Vanguard is going strong as ever. Sweet Basil, the club downstairs here, the Iridium, and even the Blue Note, and the small places. And also what I think, it's a good climate for students in school are finding more work. Now they're not making the salaries that they should be making. They have a lot of clubs in the East Village, jazz clubs, and the students work there. The wages are horrible really, I wish they could get better wages. But in order to learn how to play jazz you've got to play jazz. Playing is one of the best vehicles for learning this music. And this is probably the only reason why they do. Some of the places look like dumps, but you can go in and you can hear some of the best music. And it's usually the good players that want to play. And some of them have steady gigs you know, like they may have one night here and a night in another club, you know a little extra money for them. But it gives them a chance to play. There used to be this club, I think it's still going, I haven't been there in a long time, it's down in the Village. Anyway, it's a club, there's no alcohol. And the guy doesn't want any. He doesn't want a liquor license because it would stop a lot of the students, the younger students, from coming there. And that's what it's for. And the students — he does hire a band — but there's a lot of sitting in going on. But not having a liquor license too, sometimes students are playing in there too on the weekends, and they'll start a jam session at two in the morning and not finish until ten the same morning. Like Saturday night until like ten o'clock Sunday morning.

MR: Well that's kind of keeping with a tradition that's been — from what I've read — how many of the great musicians learned, in those situations. Those classic Kansas City jam sessions that used to last —

JM: This is something, the word kind of got out, telling about my life history and how I learned to play. The phrase always jumps out, these students are so lucky to have a jazz school, not just this school but all the schools, the students are lucky. Because they didn't have jazz schools when I was coming up. In fact I got expelled once for a week for practicing jazz in the practice room. That's why I dropped out of college, because I wasn't learning what I wanted to play, I wasn't allowed to play jazz there, I wanted to be a jazz musician. And I tell them, I sort of you might say, learned to play jazz on the streets. Because I would go out even as a teenager, like say when I was 15, 16 and 17, where all the jazz clubs were on the south side. Nobody ever checked IDs in those days.

We're talking about '40, even late '30s. The days of the so-called "Untouchables," you have seen that program? And the clubs worked long hours in those days. They'd start playing like nine or ten o'clock and finish at four. That was the curfew, five in the morning on Saturday night. And they were allowed to open at seven. I mean they'd open for business but the music wouldn't start until — I mean seven in the morning. The music always started at like nine or ten the night before. And there were nights I'd hit a half a dozen clubs. And it was really a camaraderie, with the old musicians and the young musicians then. You know they would invite you to sit in. "Hey you want to play something? Come on" if they knew that you could play well enough to sit in. And that's how I learned in my younger days, how to play or how to accompany horn, and I tell them this and they're like wow. And I tell them this to encourage them to go out and play as much as they can. That's the best way. And you're lucky to have a school where you can learn all the other things that are needed. You know you get the ear training and ensemble work and composing, arranging, etcetera. And the students are lucky to have a school. Me? I had to get it the hard way. And so the story got out among the students. They would tell the incoming students, "Get him to tell you the story about the old days."

MR: Yeah, the old days.

JM: So now, I found out I wasn't the only one, that Benny Powell the trombone player does the same thing, well he's got quite a history too. And Billy Harper, the tenor player. So I guess the three of us were the ones who were doing it most you know, so Benny Powell proposed a project we're going to do soon, called the Trio of Griots. I think Griot means —

MR: Storytellers.

JM: Yeah. And as a group we're going to hold sessions like that in the auditorium at school. We're going to tell about the old days and the school is for it, they're really high on doing it.

MR: That's great.

JM: So we're in the process of putting that together now. You know we'll do it separate and we'll do it together, for the whole school.

MR: Sure. Well that's why we're doing this too.

JM: Yeah. The same thing, right, yeah.

MR: Right. And it won't be long I'm sure before I'm reading some CD of some new upcoming star and they're going to mention Junior Mance as showing me this or that. I'm sure it will happen.

JM: Yeah. But I really love teaching. You know I didn't think I would like it as much as I did. In fact it was Chico Hamilton and Arnie Lawrence that convinced me. Chico is still there

teaching too, and he was there from the beginning. Arnie isn't anymore. Arnie moved to Israel where he started a jazz school there.

MR: No kidding?

JM: Yeah. But he was one of the founders of the New School jazz program. So when they asked me to come in and teach the blues I said, "I don't know," I said, "I don't have teaching credentials." You know I figured if you're going to teach at a university, you've got to have —

MR: A piece of paper or something that says here, you can do this.

JM: Yeah. And that's about when the time started where in some schools, especially in the east here, like well put it this way, they gave me an application to fill out just as a formal thing, and on one line it says "Degrees" but in parenthesis it says "desirable but not necessary."

MR: Oh. Wow. Yeah.

JM: And it's not just for the music department. I found out like most of the adjunct teachers, like in journalism or in the language department, it's the same thing.

MR: Right. They've learned it by doing it.

JM: By doing it. And this is what they want. Because like what they said about the school, they want to turn out more performers. Because teachers, you know like take somebody that's been to music school for four years, and this is not speaking of it negatively, but they put their four years in and get their degree. The next day they start teaching. And what do they do? They turn out more teachers. But they want people who have been out there doing it. Like in journalism most of the people weren't teaching journalism. They worked for maybe the *New York Times* or the *Daily News* or *Time/Life*. And they've been there. They're doing it. And this is what they want. They want to turn out more performers. Because there's too many teachers driving cabs because there's an overabundance.

MR: It's self-perpetuating, teachers making teachers.

JM: It's that way with performers too. We cross that bridge when we come to it.

MR: Right I guess so.

JM: But at least with performers you know they can go on the road.

MR: Yeah. And many can teach part time like you do.

JM: Yeah. And I love it. I intend to continue doing it. One thing, it's been good for me, like especially since we got this big raise that we're getting and all of that. It's enabling me to be selective about the jobs I want to play, about going out of town. I don't have to take jobs because I need the money anymore. And I'm doing two things that I like. I'm doing performing that I like and performing where I enjoy performing, and teaching, which I've grown to love teaching.

MR: Well this has been a real treat again. You look great. Congratulations on your recent marriage. And I'm glad things are going well for you.

JM: They're going very well, yeah. I have no complaints.

MR: And let me know when you're going to be at Zinno's.

JM: Okay. I'm going to be there the first week in March.

MR: Oh. Well, Tim, we'll have to come back down.

JM: They do a Wednesday through Saturday week now. On Monday and Tuesday, or Sunday, Monday and Tuesday, which are slow nights, they have like entertainment, but the main heavy jazz is like Wednesday through Saturday. So the first week in March we'll be there with the quartet.

MR: All right.

JM: So if you're in town, please come by and be my guest.

MR: Thanks again for bringing the recordings.

JM: And I'll send you the new "Harlem Lullaby."

MR: Please. I'll guard it with my life.

JM: All right, Monk, it's been a pleasure. Thank you.